



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 8.1 : MATCHING SCALES TO CHORDS – A GUIDE TO UNLOCKING HARMONIC FREEDOM

Introduction: The Harmony Behind Matching Scales to Chords

Matching scales to chords is an essential skill for any guitarist. It helps you identify the correct notes to use when soloing, comping, or creating melodies over a chord progression. Understanding which scales fit over which chords allows you to create more melodic and harmonically interesting phrases.

In this lesson, we'll break down the relationship between scales and chords, explore how to find compatible scales for different chord types, and provide practical exercises to apply these concepts in your playing.

The Relationship Between Scales and Chords

Every chord is built from a scale. By knowing the notes within a chord, you can determine which scales to play over it. Scales provide a set of notes that sound harmonically consonant over a given chord or chord progression.

Basic Principle:

- A chord is made up of three or more notes, which are derived from a scale.
- To match a scale to a chord, use a scale that includes all the chord tones (the notes that make up the chord).

For example:

- A **C major chord** (C, E, G) is derived from the **C major scale** (C, D, E, F, G, A, B).
 - When soloing over a C major chord, the **C major scale** is a good starting point because it contains the notes C, E, and G.
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Finding the Right Scale for a Chord

Different chords require different scales to match harmonically. Let's explore how to choose the right scale for various chord types:

1. Major Chords

- **Chord Structure:** Root, Major 3rd, Perfect 5th (e.g., C, E, G).
- **Matching Scales:** Major Scale, Major Pentatonic, Lydian Mode.

Example:



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- For a C major chord, use the C major scale (C, D, E, F, G, A, B).

Note: The Lydian mode (C, D, E, F#, G, A, B) is also a great choice, as it raises the 4th, creating a brighter sound.

2. Minor Chords

- **Chord Structure:** Root, Minor 3rd, Perfect 5th (e.g., C, Eb, G).
- **Matching Scales:** Minor Scale, Minor Pentatonic, Dorian Mode, Aeolian Mode.

Example:

- For a C minor chord, use the C natural minor scale (C, D, Eb, F, G, Ab, Bb).

Note: The Dorian mode (C, D, Eb, F, G, A, Bb) works well for a slightly brighter sound, especially when playing over minor 7th chords.

3. Dominant 7th Chords

- **Chord Structure:** Root, Major 3rd, Perfect 5th, Minor 7th (e.g., C, E, G, Bb).
- **Matching Scales:** Mixolydian Mode, Blues Scale.

Example:

- For a C7 chord, use the C Mixolydian scale (C, D, E, F, G, A, Bb).

Note: The Mixolydian mode is a major scale with a lowered 7th, matching the dominant 7th chord's structure perfectly.

4. Minor 7th Chords

- **Chord Structure:** Root, Minor 3rd, Perfect 5th, Minor 7th (e.g., C, Eb, G, Bb).
- **Matching Scales:** Dorian Mode, Minor Scale, Minor Pentatonic.

Example:

- For a C minor 7 chord, use the C Dorian scale (C, D, Eb, F, G, A, Bb).

5. Diminished Chords

- **Chord Structure:** Root, Minor 3rd, Diminished 5th (e.g., C, Eb, Gb).
- **Matching Scales:** Diminished Scale (Whole-Half), Locrian Mode.

Example:

- For a C diminished chord, use the C diminished scale (C, D, Eb, F, Gb, Ab, Bb).



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6. Half-Diminished Chords (Minor 7b5)

- **Chord Structure:** Root, Minor 3rd, Diminished 5th, Minor 7th (e.g., C, Eb, Gb, Bb).
- **Matching Scales:** Locrian Mode.

Example:

- For a Cmin7b5 chord, use the C Locrian scale (C, Db, Eb, F, Gb, Ab, Bb).

How to Match Scales to a Chord Progression

Matching scales to a single chord is straightforward, but applying this concept to a chord progression requires understanding how the chords relate to one another.

1. Analyze the Chord Progression:

- Determine the key of the progression.
- Identify whether the progression is diatonic (all chords belong to one key) or uses non-diatonic chords.

2. Choose a Scale that Fits All Chords:

- If the progression is diatonic, use the scale of the key for the entire progression.
- If the progression includes non-diatonic chords, use a different scale for each chord or use modes that fit the altered chords.

Example:

For a chord progression in C major: C - F - G (I-IV-V), use the C major scale over the entire progression.

For a progression with a non-diatonic chord: Cmaj7 - E7 - Am7, use C major over Cmaj7, E Mixolydian over E7, and A minor over Am7.

Exercises for Practicing Matching Scales to Chords

Exercise 1: Matching Scales to Major and Minor Chords

1. Play a major chord (e.g., C major).
2. Practice using the C major scale and C major pentatonic scale over the chord.
3. Repeat the exercise with a minor chord (e.g., C minor) using the C natural minor scale and C minor pentatonic scale.

Exercise 2: Matching Scales to a Chord Progression



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1. Create a simple chord progression (e.g., C - Am - F - G).
2. Use the C major scale to solo over the entire progression.
3. Try adding other scales or modes (e.g., C major pentatonic, C Lydian) to see how they affect the harmony.

Exercise 3: Using Modes Over Dominant Chords

1. Play a dominant 7th chord (e.g., G7).
2. Use the Mixolydian scale (G Mixolydian) to create a solo line.
3. Experiment with the Blues scale or other modes (e.g., Lydian dominant) to add different colors.